

I don't have a lot of sympathy for the Teresas of the world. If you are managing your finances the way you should, you're not going to dole out a dollar, never mind 40 grand, to a man you've never met. Teresa paid a high price for not performing due diligence on her partner (more about that in [chapter 2](#)). But love, even just the promise of it, is a powerful drug. Teresa thought she'd found it with Philip, and in her mind, that was worth any cost. Problem was, it wasn't love at all. It was extortion. Beware of emotions when it comes to romance, because when logical thinking escapes you, a cash drain isn't too far behind.

Internet dating sites are still largely unregulated, which means they are a minefield of potential scammers and thieves. The Canadian Anti-Fraud Centre estimates Canadians lost at least \$17 million to online dating scams in 2012. Remarkably, fewer than 5 percent of fraud cases are reported to authorities, perhaps because victims are ashamed of having been duped or simply because people tend to be tight-lipped about love and money. Unfortunately, if you're the target of an online dating scam, you're going to lose both.

The number one rule in real estate is "location, location, location," and the number one rule in relationships is "time, time, time." Time is the best litmus test for true love. All told, Teresa had known Philip for only eight months—and I use the term "known" lightly. (In Teresa's case, she made the ultimate mistake of never coming face to face with Philip at all and never getting to know him for real.) Most scammers don't have the patience or the resources to pull off a long con. The longer you know someone, the more layers of deception and posturing get peeled away, until you're finally face to face with the cold hard truth.

Money Mistake: *You've Met Mr. or Ms. Wonderful—Time to Get Married!*

The Fix: *Follow the Three-Year Rule*

My mother had a simple rule: wait three years before marrying someone. She learned this lesson the hard way. Her courtship with